It Is Settled

A Clear and Simple Tour of the Book of Romans

“After the suffering of his soul, he will see the light and be satisfied. ...” Isaiah 53:11

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Scripture quotations are from the World English Bible (WEB), Classic American English edition, a public-domain translation. Ellipses (…) indicate omitted words. Paraphrases are identified in the text.

Purpose of this Book

This book was written to help the reader understand a simple, yet often misunderstood, truth:

what God has already resolved does not need to be re-resolved by us.

Many believers live as if their standing before God is fragile, uncertain, or dependent on continuous performance. The message of Romans presents a very different picture: one in which God acts decisively, justly, and finally.

This book does not pretend to be technical or academic.

It is written in clear and thoughtful language so that the reader can follow the flow of Paul’s message without prior theological training.

Romans will be treated as a **message to be understood**, not just verses to be quoted.

How to Use This Book

- Read calmly
- Follow the argument as it unfolds
- Allow conclusions to emerge from the text
- Resist the temptation to insert assumptions

The goal is not to give you opinions about Romans, but to show you what it declares settled from God’s perspective, then you’ll be better prepared to examine it verse by verse.

Prelude

Reality Doesn’t Start With Us

It’s easy to live as if reality begins where our thoughts begin.
Or where our emotions begin.
Or where our questions begin.

I think we all tend to have a high opinion of ourselves. Maybe I have been successful and feel I deserve the respect of others.

What if someone is arrogant? We would immediately say that his view of himself is not real. Yet he experiences his superiority as real.

But feeling natural does not make something true. It wasn’t until I stopped to think about it that I realized how fragile it is.

If reality begins with me, it changes when I change. It shifts with my mood, my clarity, my energy. It changes with my last failure or my last “good day.”

That kind of reality is shaky at best.

But the Bible does not allow for that starting point. It begins with a quiet but absolute affirmation: God is.

> In the beginning, God …
> — Genesis 1:1

God is. Not as a conclusion we reach, but as a reality that precedes us. Before any human being interprets anything, God already exists, already acts, already speaks. The unseen God established everything that is seen.

> … so that what is seen has not been made out of things which are visible.
> — Hebrews 11:3

Science can help us observe and describe the visible world. But it does not determine what reality is. It is a human tool for testing explanations and discovering patterns. Reality exists before we investigate it. Our understanding can change as we learn, but discovering something does not make it true. It was true before we knew it.

Here’s a question worth asking slowly:

Am I willing to accept that reality is true before I understand it?

Because that is what revelation entails.

Science investigates what can be observed. We can study what God has made, but we cannot discover His purposes by examining creation. For that, He must speak.

Scripture exists because God is not silent. Not because human beings deserve it, and not because they have successfully sought it, but because God decided to make Himself known.

> The secret things belong to Yahweh our God; but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, …
> — Deuteronomy 29:29

When God speaks, we receive something we could never have supplied for ourselves. His word does not become true because we understand it. Understanding is how we come to recognize what He has already said.

That establishes something from the beginning: truth is not constructed from human experience; it is declared by divine authority.

> Of old I have known from your testimonies, that you have founded them forever.
> — Psalm 119:152

God Spoke Before We Respond

That is not just a pious idea. It is the foundation of objectivity.

If we reverse that order, everything that follows becomes unstable. Even beautiful words like “grace,” “faith,” and “assurance” become slippery.

Grace begins to sound like opinion. Before long, it is treated as a way to escape culpability—to sin without consequence, as though one could “get away with murder.”

Grace becomes a kind of sinful bliss: not God’s answer to sin, but permission to ignore it.

Faith begins to sound like effort.

Security begins to sound like presumption. And then, without realizing it, we end up living not under revelation, but under interpretation.

Isn’t that the root of a lot of our spiritual anxiety?

Not that we do not know what the Bible says, but that we do not know what authority it has in the face of what we consider real.

God is not one piece in the world. He is the world’s point of reference.

Saying “God is the center” may sound like a religious cliché. But in Romans—and throughout the Bible—that phrase has a concrete meaning: God is not an accessory to improve life. He is the One who defines what is real, true, and good.

> … even from everlasting to everlasting, you are God.
> — Psalm 90:2

This means that God does not enter my story to collaborate with my plans. My story exists within His reality.

> For of him and through him and to him are all things. …
> — Romans 11:36

I hope you do not hear me saying that your opinion is irrelevant or that it does not matter. It does matter.

But my opinion of myself—or of you—does not determine what is real.

I hope you have a firm grasp on that before we move forward.

God has revealed Himself. He has made known His plans, His purposes, and His desire for my life. That means I am no longer neutral before Him. I am responsible for what He has made known.

What if God is not one perspective among others, but the criterion of all perspectives?

It is easy to treat God as one point of view among many: a religious opinion alongside other ways of seeing the world.

But the Bible does not speak of God that way.

God is not simply one perspective from which to look at reality. He is the One who establishes it and sustains it. He defines what is true, what is real, and what is right. Truth is not decided by comparing human opinions until we settle on the one we prefer. It begins with what God has revealed.

My experience cannot sit as a judge on His word. My conscience cannot have the last word. My performance cannot define my position.

> "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, and your ways are not my ways," says Yahweh.
>
> — Isaiah 55:8

This does not make human experience unreal. Experience is real. But it is not the final point of reference. It must be understood in light of what God has made known.

The same is true of feelings. They are real, powerful, and meaningful. But they change. They can be strong and still be wrong. They cannot define reality by themselves. They need something steadier than themselves.

Nor is conscience set aside. Conscience still speaks. But it is not the highest authority. It too must come under the truth God has revealed.

God does not compete with experience, feelings, or conscience. He gives each of them its proper place. He is not one more voice in the conversation. He is the One by whom every other voice is measured.

An Example from 1 John

The author of 1 John begins his letter with what he and the other witnesses heard, saw, and touched. He is speaking about someone they knew: Jesus Christ. The life they announce was revealed to them (1 John 1:1–3).

Their experience matters. But they are not asking us to accept whatever they happened to feel. They are passing on what they received from Him:

> This is the message which we have heard from him and announce to you, that God is light, and in him is no darkness at all.
>
> — 1 John 1:5

That message gives us something by which to examine our claims.

Suppose I say I have fellowship with God while walking in darkness. Does saying it make it true? John says no. Suppose I claim to have no sin. My conviction does not make me sinless. John calls it self-deception (1 John 1:6–8).

Later, 1 John addresses the accusing heart:

> … if our heart condemns us, God is greater than our heart, and knows all things.
>
> — 1 John 3:20

He had just urged his readers to love in deed and truth, rather than in words alone. That is the setting in which he speaks about persuading our hearts before God (1 John 3:18–20). The heart's accusation is not the whole account. God knows what the heart does not.

John does not ask us to switch off experience, feelings, or conscience. He gives us the correct perspective by which we examine them rather than to let them have the final word.

Near the end of the letter, he brings us back to God's own testimony: God has given eternal life, and that life is in His Son. John writes so that those who believe in the Son's name may know they have eternal life (1 John 5:11–13).

The question is not whether that message feels convincing. God has spoken.

How Does Human Life Really Work?

None of us comes to life empty-handed. We all rely on something when we decide what is true, what matters, and how we ought to live.

Some trust reason. Some trust experience. Some trust freedom, intuition, identity, community, morality, or tradition. Even the

person who says, “I don’t believe in anything,” has not stepped outside the question. He has simply chosen what he will trust.

The center does not always announce itself. But it shows itself.

What we trust shapes what we believe. What we believe affects what we value. And what we value shows up in the way we live.

Romans will show us that behavior is not the whole problem. It reveals something deeper: God has been displaced.

Conduct matters. Paul will name actions, desires, and ways of thinking that God judges. He does not excuse them by calling them symptoms.

But he does not begin with a list of behaviors. He goes back to what came before them. People knew God, yet they did not glorify Him as God or give Him thanks. They exchanged His glory for created things (Romans 1:21–23).

That is why behavior by itself cannot heal what is wrong. Paul exposes what people do to show what has happened in their relationship to God. The truth has been suppressed. The Creator has been exchanged for something created.

The conduct that follows is real. It is sinful. It is not the whole story.

Paul is not simply saying, “Behave well.” He is showing why outward correction cannot restore a person to God. A life can be adjusted on the outside while the deeper refusal remains untouched.

How can behavior heal what behavior itself is displaying?

If the heart remains turned from God, good behavior can become makeup: something that covers the problem without healing it.

During my years as a missionary, I saw many well-intentioned people preach about turning your life over to God and repenting of sins already committed. Then came the warning: those who did not change their ways would go to hell.

Usually, the message ended with an invitation to begin that change—to raise a hand, walk to the front, or make some public declaration of commitment to “follow Jesus.”

I heard this often enough that I concluded becoming a Christian meant changing what could be seen.

The Collapse of Man Is Not Just Moral

Romans does not begin by saying that humanity needs better behavior. Paul begins with what happened before the behavior.

Paul begins before the moral list.

People knew God. Yet they did not honor Him as God or give Him thanks. They exchanged His glory for created things.

This is the heart of the matter. It has to do with how God is regarded—what is treated as true, worthy, and ultimate. God is known, but He is no longer honored as God. His glory is exchanged for images of what He has made.

The behavior that follows is not excused or minimized. But Paul begins with the exchange, because that is where the collapse began.

When God is not honored as God, a person does not become neutral. The exchange changes what is worshiped.

Paul says that people served the creature rather than the Creator. Later, he will show that even religion and morality can be used to claim an advantage before God.

Paul then describes what follows from this exchange. Three times he says that God “gave them up”: to uncleanness, to vile passions, and to a reprobate mind (Romans 1:24, 26, 28).

The collapse reaches the body, the desires, and the mind that decides what is fitting.

These are not unrelated offenses. The truth of God has been exchanged for a lie. His glory has been exchanged for images of what He made. What follows in the body and the mind does not appear out of nowhere.

We can recognize something of this. It is possible to do what is wrong, call it acceptable, and then find reasons to defend it. We can begin to approve in others what once troubled us in ourselves.

Paul ends the account there. People know God's ordinance—that those who practice such things are worthy of death—yet they not only do them, but approve of those who practice them.

Behavior still matters. Paul calls it unrighteousness, and he says God judges it. But behavior alone cannot carry the whole diagnosis. Before Paul speaks of what people do, he shows us what they have done with the God they know.

Effort may alter what appears on the surface. It cannot undo the exchange at the root.

Why the Restoration Begins with Revelation and Not Reformation

> All of your words are truth. Every one of your righteous ordinances endures forever.
>
> — Psalm 119:160

If the problem were only behavior, God would give us instructions.

If it were only desires, God would give us persuasion.

If it were just thought, God would give us information.

But God does something more radical: **He reveals himself**.

> He reveals the deep and secret things. …
>
> — Daniel 2:22
>
> For in it is revealed God's righteousness from faith to faith. …
>
> — Romans 1:17

God reveals what men cannot access

When I say that **God reveals what men cannot access**, I am affirming a real limit of the human being. It is not a matter of lack of intelligence, effort or sincerity. There are realities – who God is, where we come from, what is the meaning of life and of man – that human beings cannot reach by observation, introspection or autonomous reasoning. If God does not make himself known, man does not discover him.

That is why it is essential to understand that **God reveals the truth; Truth is not the product of human discovery**. Discovery

implies that the truth is already available and that it only needs to be found. Revelation, on the other hand, affirms that the truth **was not within reach**, and that it is God who decides to make himself known. The initiative is not in the man who seeks, but in God who speaks. Knowledge of God does not begin with human curiosity, but with God making Himself known.

Moreover, the revelation does not happen all at once or in a chaotic way. It is initiated by God and is given **progressively**. God reveals Himself in stages, in words, deeds, and promises that accumulate and become clear over time. Each revelatory act does not contradict the previous one, but rather expands it, focuses it, and prepares it for something greater. The truth does not change, but the clarity increases.

This progressive process reaches its climax in Christ. Not because there was no true revelation before, but because in Christ revelation ceases to be fragmentary and becomes personal and full. In Him, God not only speaks the truth, but embodies it. Christ is not simply one more messenger in the chain of revelation; he is the point where God makes himself known in the most complete and definitive way possible.

> God, having in the past spoken to the fathers through the prophets at many times and in various ways, has at the end of these days spoken to us by his Son, … His Son is the radiance of his glory, the very image of his substance, …
>
> — Hebrews 1:1–3

This must completely redefine how we understand truth. Truth is not something that man builds from below, but something that **God grants from above**. It is not achieved by accumulating human perspectives, but by receiving what God has chosen to show. That is why faith is not an irrational leap, but a reasonable response to a revelation that could not have occurred otherwise.

Therefore, revelation breeds responsibility, not neutrality (Romans 1:18-21).

Because the root of the problem is not just what we do. It’s what we treat as real.

With this clear, Romans can begin.

Movement 1 - God as Reference

(Romans 1:1–17)

If one approaches Romans in a hurry, it is easy to think that Paul is simply fulfilling an introduction.

A formal greeting before getting into the important stuff. But a closer reading reveals something quite different.

Paul is not opening a letter. He is **establishing a starting point**.

And that starting point is not accidental.

We usually start with ourselves. With how we feel, with what worries us, with what we don't understand, with what we would like to correct. Our reading of reality almost always begins from experience.

Paul does not do that.

Paul begins with God.

From the first line he makes it clear that the gospel is not a response built from the human crisis, but a declaration that comes from God himself.

> … a servant of Jesus Christ, … set apart for the Good News of God, …
>
> — Romans 1:1

This establishes something fundamental: before man interprets his situation, **God has already spoken**. The gospel does not arise as a progressive solution to our problems, but as an affirmation of reality as God defines it.

The apostle Paul presents himself as a servant, called and set apart. He does not introduce himself as a thinker, or as a reformer, or as someone who came to certain conclusions. He presents himself as someone **located within a previous authority**. His identity is not the origin of the message; it is evidence that the message precedes him.

This is not a minor detail. It corrects the reader from the beginning.

Because if the messenger is not the origin, then the reader cannot position himself as a judge either. The message does not depend on Paul's charisma, nor on his history, nor on his rhetorical capacity. It is not sustained by his experience. It comes from God.

> … the Good News which was preached by me, … it came to me through revelation of Jesus Christ.
>
> — Galatians 1:11–12

Here is exposed one of our most frequent temptations: to treat the truth as something we validate according to who says it or how it makes us feel. Romans leaves no room for that. From the outset it is clear that this is not a message *about* God; it is a message **from God**.

And the center of that message is not a method or a system.

He is a person.

> concerning his Son, …
>
> — Romans 1:3

Paul places the Son at the center not as a devotional figure, but as the point where reality becomes public. The gospel does not describe how human beings encounter God; it announces that **God has come to act and reveal himself**.

This completely changes the tone of Christianity.

Because many live as if the gospel were a path we take to achieve stability.

Looking back if I'm honest, I tried to figure it out exactly that way.

I had served as a missionary for thirteen years.

Sincerely.

I wanted to help people.

But more than that, I wanted to do something for God.

I was giving my best for Jesus.

I made commitments.

I promised to do better.

And, to be honest, for me, I was quite disciplined.

Sometimes I even felt a certain pride in having achieved some spiritual goals. I was on my way to becoming someone.

Other days, on the other hand, I felt completely guilty and condemned for not meeting my own expectations.

I lived in cycles.

Effort.

Achievement.

Pride.

Failure.

Guilt.

Repeat.

There was a moment when I was already deeply fatigued—spiritually and ministerially exhausted—when someone asked me a simple question:

“John, if you died today and went to heaven and God asked you:

‘Why should I let you in?’

What would you answer?”

I thought for just a second.

And I answered without hesitation:

“Because I gave Him my life.”

My friend looked at me smiling and replied:

“How interesting.

I thought it was the other way around, that He gave His life for you.”

That phrase disarmed me.

Because for the first time I understood that my answer revealed what I was really trusting.

Without realizing it, I had made the gospel my story of effort.

I did not deny it.

In a way I preached it.

But I had reduced it to a necessary message…

not enough.
certainly not sufficient.

Without realizing it, I had stripped the gospel of its power,

because I had transformed it into something that ultimately depended on me.

And that's exactly what Paul is correcting.

Paul does not present the gospel as a process that we complete.

He presents it as an intervention that has already occurred… If God has already spoken in His Son, then the question is not how to secure that message, but **the conclusions in light of something that has already been declared**. There is nothing left to negotiate, or to complete, or to demonstrate.

Here we begin to perceive something decisive: Christianity does not stand on our ability to sustain it.

This explains why Paul writes the Gospel explanation to believers.

At first glance it might seem unnecessary to re-explain the gospel to those who already believe. But Paul knows something that we easily forget: knowing information is not the same as living from an established reality.

> … To write the same things to you, to me indeed is not tiresome, but for you it is safe.
>
> — Philippians 3:1

A believer can affirm correct doctrines and still live insecurely. You can say "I'm saved" and inadvertently interpret every fall as a threat. You can talk about grace and still organize your life as if God is constantly evaluating.

Romans does not call us to add more religion to our lives. It brings us back to the good news of God concerning His Son.

As Paul unfolds that good news, he exposes what cannot bear the weight we put on it—our effort, our morality, our knowledge, even our religious advantage.

He brings us back to the one thing on which life can stand: what God has done in Christ.

Here Paul makes one of the best-known statements in the letter:

the gospel is the power of God for salvation.

Paul is not describing a message that merely inspires people to try harder. The gospel brings news of something God has done.

Paul has already said that it concerns God's Son. He will spend the rest of the letter showing what God has accomplished through Him: His righteousness revealed, redemption provided, sinners justified, enemies reconciled.

The gospel does not hand us a plan for completing our rescue. It announces God's rescue in Christ.

That is why it is power for salvation. Salvation does not rest on what a person manages to maintain. It rests on what God has accomplished and made known in His Son.

That is why Paul says that in the gospel **God's righteousness is revealed**.

He does not say, "Here is how you can make yourself righteous." He says, "For in it is revealed God's righteousness."

Paul will unfold that phrase as the letter continues. But he has already made the starting point clear: the gospel does not begin with our behavior. It begins with God—His righteousness, His Son, and His saving action.

That changes the question. It is no longer only, "Have I done enough?" The deeper question is, "What has God made known in His Son?"

Romans begins there, deliberately.

For the first 17 verses, Paul does not even begin to diagnose human sin. He begins with God: God's promised gospel, God's Son, God's power, and God's righteousness.

That order prepares us for what follows.

Sin will be named. It will be shown to be serious and judged by God. But it is not the starting point. God is.

Reality begins with God.

And once Paul has established that, he can show us what happens when God is not honored as God.

That is where he turns next.

Movement 2 - God Is Displaced

(Romans 1:18–32)

Paul does not begin with human suffering when he explains why the gospel is needed. He begins with what people know about God and what they do with that knowledge.

God has not been eliminated from the world. People have put something else in His place.

The altar has not been left empty.

It has been filled with something else.

The Truth Is Not Lost by Accident

Paul says the truth has been **suppressed**.

Not simply missed. Not merely misunderstood.

Suppressed.

The problem is not a lack of information. It is resistance to what is known.

What can be known about God is not hidden. God has made it plain through what He has created.

And yet people have done something else with that knowledge. Paul uses a strong word for it: *traded.*

> and traded the glory of the incorruptible God for the likeness of an image of corruptible man, and of birds, four-footed animals, and creeping things.
>
> — Romans 1:23

Revelation Leaves Us Without Excuse

Before Paul tells us what people do, he reminds us what God has shown.

> For the invisible things of him since the creation of the world are clearly seen, being perceived through the things that are made, even his everlasting power and divinity, that they may be without excuse.
>
> — Romans 1:20

Paul is not describing people who had no knowledge of God. He says they knew God. The problem was their response.

> … they didn’t glorify him as God, and didn’t give thanks, but became vain in their reasoning, and their senseless heart was darkened.
>
> — Romans 1:21

That is why the behavior Paul describes next is not a list of unrelated offenses. It follows a refusal he has already named. The truth has been suppressed. God’s glory has been exchanged.

Their conduct still matters. God judges it. But conduct does not tell the whole story. Changing outward behavior alone cannot undo their refusal to honor God or give Him thanks.

Paul is showing why the human problem needs more than reform. It needs God’s rescue.

God Acts in the Face of Rejection

When people suppress what God has shown them, they do not enter some safe space where they can define reality for themselves. Paul begins by saying that God’s wrath is revealed against this rejection. Then, as he traces what follows, he says three times that God gave them up.

This is crucial: **God acts in the face of the rejection of revelation**.

His action is tied to what people have done. They trade His glory for images of created things and His truth for a lie. *Therefore* God gives them up. *For this reason* He gives them up again. And *even as* they refuse to have Him in their knowledge, He gives them up to a reprobate mind.

This is no sign that God approves of the exchange. Nor does it give people the freedom they imagined. What follows exposes what that

exchange produces. Their bodies are dishonored. Their desires and their thinking become part of the collapse.

Paul has already said that God's righteousness is revealed in the gospel. Now he says that God's wrath is revealed as well. The giving up is His judgment. People may put something else in His place, but they cannot change who He is or escape the reality He has established.

The trouble reaches further than outward conduct. It begins when people refuse to honor the Creator and give His place to what He created.

What kind of life follows when created things take the Creator's place?

It may seem workable for a while, perhaps even sincere. But Paul now traces how deeply it comes apart: in conduct, in desire, and in thinking.

The First Collapse: Behavior

> Therefore God also gave them up in the lusts of their hearts to uncleanness, …
>
> — Romans 1:24

Paul's first description of God giving people up concerns their bodies. He says that, in the lusts of their hearts, they were given up to uncleanness, so that their bodies would be dishonored among themselves.

This comes immediately after the exchange Paul has described: the glory of the incorruptible God traded for images of created things.

The behavior is not unimportant. It is sin, and it stands under the wrath of God. But Paul will not let us treat it as an isolated problem. The word **therefore** takes us back to what has already happened: people knew God, yet refused to honor Him as God or give Him thanks.

Perhaps this is why conduct is so often treated as the whole problem. It is what can be seen. The solution then seems obvious:

change what people do. Add rules. Apply pressure. Watch more closely. Compare ourselves with others.

But rules cannot make a person honor God. They cannot make a person give thanks. They cannot undo the exchange Paul has described.

That is why Paul begins with a diagnosis before he gives any command. The body's dishonor matters. But it shows us something that began earlier.

The Second Collapse: Desire

> For this reason, God gave them up to vile passions. …
>
> — Romans 1:26

Paul now speaks more directly about desire.

God gave them up to vile passions. Paul describes women changing the natural function into what is against nature, and men leaving the natural function of the woman and burning in lust toward one another. He does not present these desires as harmless or private. He calls the actions that follow inappropriate, and he says that those involved received in themselves the due penalty of their error.

The point is not that behavior has ceased to matter. It matters deeply. But Romans 1 does not leave the problem at the level of what can be seen.

The exchange reaches desire itself.

People who exchange the truth of God for a lie do not merely make a wrong choice and then move on untouched. Their desires become part of the collapse. What they pursue, what they want, and what they do with their bodies now show the same rejection of the Creator.

Paul has already said that God gave them up. The next movement brings us to their thinking. There, Paul will also speak of people who know God's ordinance and yet approve those who practice what is wrong.

That is where the question of values belongs.

The Third Collapse: Thinking

> Even as they refused to have God in their knowledge, God gave them up to a reprobate mind, to do those things which are not fitting.
>
> — Romans 1:28

Paul ends this account by speaking about the mind.

He does not say that people have no knowledge. They knew God, yet they did not honor Him as God or give Him thanks. Paul will end this section by saying that they know God’s ordinance—that those who practice these things are worthy of death.

The problem is not that they have stopped thinking. Paul has already said that they reason and claim wisdom. Their thinking becomes vain—futile—not because they lack knowledge, but because, knowing God, they refuse to honor Him as God or give Him thanks.

The mind does not stand apart from the exchange. It becomes part of it.

We know the temptation. We can make a decision, then begin looking for reasons that will let us keep it. We can reinterpret what is true, not because we have found the truth, but because we do not want to surrender what we have chosen.

Paul does not give us a complete psychology of every decision. He gives us something more serious: God gives people who refuse to have Him in their knowledge up to a reprobate mind, to do those things which are not fitting.

The long list that follows shows what such a mind produces. Then Paul takes us one step further. People know God’s ordinance. They know that those who practice such things are worthy of death. Yet they not only do them, but approve of those who practice them.

That is where values enter the picture. What God judges as wrong is not only practiced. It is approved.

A Devastating and Necessary Diagnosis

This triple collapse—behavior, desires, thinking—has a necessary implication: **the answer cannot be self-salvation**. If behavior is disordered, discipline is not enough. If desires are inverted, exhortation is not enough. If thinking is disoriented, education is not enough to put people right before God.

The problem is not superficial. Nor is it merely structural or cultural. **It is spiritual**. Paul is describing a condition that reaches the heart of the human being. It is not only a matter of what a person does, or even how he thinks. It begins with the refusal to have God in his knowledge.

Here Paul begins the case he will complete in Romans 3:20. Information is not absent. People knew God. They know His ordinance. But they suppress the truth, their reasoning becomes vain, and what God judges as wrong is practiced and approved.

A harder question follows:

What can people do when they know God's ordinance, yet practice and approve what He says is worthy of death?

Paul has announced the gospel as the power of God for salvation, but he has not yet unfolded what God has done. For now, he is showing the depth of the human condition. People can know God and suppress the truth. They can know His ordinance and approve what it condemns. More information cannot undo that exchange.

If there is to be rescue, God must act. That is why Paul continues to trace the problem before he unfolds the answer. The gospel is not a program of self-improvement. It is the power of God.

This diagnosis gives no reader a place of moral superiority. Paul's next words turn immediately to the person who judges another: "Therefore you are without excuse, O man, whoever you are who judge."

No one can put himself right before God from inside this collapse. Paul will continue until every mouth is closed and no one can claim justification by works of the law.

When we do not see how deep the problem goes, grace can seem excessive and justification irresponsible. When we do, God's intervention begins to look necessary.

The Transition Point

So far, Romans has done two things:

1. It has established God as God—the Creator whom people know, yet refuse to honor or thank.
2. It has shown what follows when people exchange His glory and truth for created things and a lie.

Romans has already announced the gospel as the power of God for salvation. It has not yet unfolded God’s answer to the human condition.

Until the problem is seen clearly, God’s answer can seem like help for human effort. Paul continues through Romans 2 and 3:20, showing that both Jews and Greeks are under sin and that no one is justified by works of the law. Then comes the decisive turn.

Paul will not present a program by which people save themselves. He will show what God does when they cannot put themselves right before Him.

That is the heart of the gospel.

Movement 3 - No Human Advantage

(Romans 2:1-3:20)

After describing the collapse that follows when people refuse to honor God as God, Paul does something that may be uncomfortable for many readers: he **does not allow anyone to stand outside the diagnosis**.

He does not allow the reader to remain a moral spectator, analyzing the world from a supposed height. The danger is not only doing what is wrong. It is seeing what is wrong in others and thinking, *I am not included.*

So far, it might seem easy to nod. It is easy to say, “Yes, that’s the way the world is.” Easy to think of others. Easy to locate the problem in “outsiders.”

But Paul does not allow it.

In Romans 2, Paul begins to disarm one of the most common human defenses: **comparative advantage**. That inward feeling of being better than others—not necessarily because one is a saint, but because one has something: more information, more discipline, more culture, more tradition, more religious language, more sense of justice.

It is a subtle illusion: *I’m not like them.*

As long as that illusion remains, people can keep the diagnosis at a distance.

That is why Paul turns to the one who judges. He makes it personal: “you who judge.” He does not say that recognizing evil in another person is itself the problem. He says that the one who judges practices the same things. The person who condemns evil in someone else is not therefore outside God’s judgment. God’s judgment is according to truth.

Paul then presses the conversation deeper. God’s goodness, forbearance, and patience are meant to lead to repentance. But a hard and unrepentant heart can despise that goodness and

treasure up wrath instead. Patience does not remove accountability.

In Romans 2:12–29, Paul does not dismiss the law, identity, or outward signs as meaningless. He says that hearers of the law are not righteous before God, but doers of the law will be justified. That means having the law cannot become a refuge. A person can know God's will, teach others, glory in the law, and yet dishonor God by breaking it.

The same is true of circumcision. Paul says it profits if one is a doer of the law, but that it becomes uncircumcision when one is a transgressor. The issue is not whether these privileges are real. The issue is whether they can shield anyone who does not do what God requires.

In Romans 3:1–8, Paul recognizes real privilege, especially that the Jews were entrusted with the revelations of God. But even that privilege cannot become a basis for trust in themselves. Human unfaithfulness does not overturn God's faithfulness, and human unrighteousness does not excuse human sin.

Then, in Romans 3:9–20, Paul comes to the necessary closure: **there is no human advantage that can reverse the diagnosis**. Jews and Greeks are all under sin. No group, no privilege, no knowledge, and no work of the law can justify a person before God.

The law does not justify. Through the law comes the knowledge of sin.

Judgment Is Not Avoided by Acknowledging the Problem

Paul begins by dismantling a silent but deeply held assumption: that **recognizing evil in others is tantamount to being safe from it**. That clearly seeing the disorder of others, denouncing it, or even condemning it automatically places us in a different, safer, more correct position.

Judging the messiness of others can produce a momentary sense of moral clarity. It creates distance. It gives the impression of being on the right side of the line. As long as the problem has an

external face, the diagnosis seems controllable. Evil is “over there,” and I am “here.”

But Paul introduces a question that disarms that comfort at its root:

Do you think that you will escape the judgment of God?

Paul’s point is direct. The one who judges another practices the same things. In judging another, he condemns himself. Recognizing the standard does not put him outside its judgment. It removes his excuse.

Paul is not giving a complete account of every kind of moral evaluation. He is exposing the person who condemns in another what he practices himself. The false security is the idea that identifying the problem is equivalent to not participating in it. That naming evil is the same as being free from evil.

The problem is not that the judge correctly sees the disorder. The problem is that he treats that recognition as though it protects him from God’s judgment. He condemns what is wrong in another, while his own conduct remains under the same judgment.

That is why judgment, far from avoiding God’s judgment, can expose the very thing the judge hoped to avoid. God’s judgment is according to truth. The one who judges another while doing the same things does not stand above that truth. He stands under it.

And here Paul’s question reaches us strongly:

Isn’t this one of our favorite shelters?

Not to deny the truth, but to imagine that recognizing it is enough.

Not to reject the diagnosis, but to apply it selectively.

Not to stand outside the standard, but to forget that it judges us too.

Thus, judgment can become a refined mode of escape. Paul does not allow that evasion to remain intact. The person who judges while practicing the same things is not beyond the diagnosis. He is included in it.

Morality Gives No Advantage

Paul then turns to a kind of reader who may feel relatively secure: the one who sees himself as responsible, disciplined, and concerned with what is good. Compared with the disorder described above, he may seem to be “on the right side.”

But Paul does not let moral comparison become an advantage before God.

Paul is not pausing here to praise morality, measure its social value, or offer it as a path to God. He is setting the standard of God’s judgment. Hearing the law is not enough. The doers of the law will be justified.

Then Paul completes the argument. Jews and Greeks are all under sin. There is no one righteous, and by works of the law no flesh will be justified before God. The standard has been stated; the human claim to meet it has been closed.

Romans is not measuring social usefulness. It is dealing with the judgment of God. In that judgment, hearing the law is not enough. Paul says that it is the doers of the law who will be justified. This means that possessing the standard cannot become a safe-conduct.

A person can know God’s will, teach others, glory in the law, and still dishonor God by breaking it. The problem is not that the standard is wrong. The problem is that knowing and speaking the standard do not excuse the person who fails to do it.

That is why Paul does not stop at moral appearance. He addresses the person who judges another while practicing the same things. The judgment of another person’s sin does not place the judge above God’s judgment. God’s judgment is according to truth.

Here comes the inevitable question:

What happens when morality becomes the basis of security?

It becomes comparison. The person begins to rest in the thought, *I am not like them.* But God’s judgment does not ask whether I compare well with someone else. It asks whether I have done what He requires.

That ground may seem solid, but it is fragile. If my claim rests on being better than someone else, I have not answered the question

of God’s judgment. I have only chosen a comparison that favors me.

That is why Paul does not allow that ground. Not because morality is bad, and not because conduct does not matter, but because no moral reputation, privilege, or work of the law can justify a person before God.

Romans 2:13 establishes the standard: the doers of the law will be justified. Romans 3:20 gives the conclusion: by works of the law, no flesh will be justified in God’s sight. Through the law comes the knowledge of sin.

Religion Doesn’t Solve the Problem Either

After showing that neither obvious disorder nor moral comparison gives anyone an advantage before God, Paul takes a more delicate step. He turns to the person who bears the name of a Jew, rests on the law, glories in God, knows His will, and approves the things that are excellent.

These are real privileges. Paul will say in Romans 3 that the Jew has advantage “much in every way,” because they were entrusted with the revelations of God.

But privilege does not excuse disobedience.

The problem is not in the revelation. The law makes God’s will known. It gives the person who has it knowledge of the truth. But Paul asks a direct question: “You therefore who teach another, don’t you teach yourself?” The one who preaches that a man should not steal may steal. The one who says that a man should not commit adultery may commit adultery. The one who glories in the law may dishonor God by breaking it.

That is the distinction Paul makes:

Knowing God’s will does not excuse disobeying it.

The person who has the law cannot use the law as a credential before God. The law by which he judges others also stands over him. Paul has already said that those who sin under the law will be judged by the law.

So a difficult but necessary question arises:

What happens when knowledge of God's will becomes a claim of personal advantage?

It becomes a refuge rather than a summons to obedience. A person can speak of the truth, teach the truth, and even glory in the truth, while his own conduct contradicts it. The privilege is real, but it does not shield the transgressor from God's judgment.

That is why Paul is not attacking Scripture or denying the privilege of revelation. He is showing that clarity is not a substitute for doing what God requires. Bearing the name, possessing the law, knowing God's will, and teaching others cannot justify the person who breaks the law.

Thus, Paul closes another possible way out. It is not enough to be moral. It is not enough to be religious. It is not enough to know the truth. None of these claims can put a transgressor right before God.

The Underlying Problem: Listening Without Responding

At this point, Paul is no longer speaking only about obvious disorder, religious privilege, or moral comparison.

He is dismantling an idea common to all: that **having access to the truth gives someone an advantage before God**.

But the truth does not make a person righteous by proximity. It becomes the standard by which he is judged.

Paul insists: it is not the hearers of the law who are righteous in the sight of God, but those who keep it.

This does not reassure the person who has heard the law. It removes hearing the law as a claim of advantage.

The question it raises is unavoidable:

Who can claim to have done what God requires?

Paul has not yet brought the argument to its conclusion. But he will.

When All Comparison Collapses

As the argument progresses, one thing becomes apparent: **every human claim to advantage has been brought under God's judgment**.

The person without the law cannot claim ignorance.

The person who judges cannot claim distance from sin.

The person who has the law cannot claim that hearing it makes him righteous.

The person entrusted with God's revelations cannot claim that privilege excuses unfaithfulness.

And so Paul comes to his conclusion: Jews and Greeks are all under sin.

This is not a rhetorical exaggeration. Paul is not merely saying that everyone has committed individual wrong acts. He is saying that no group and no person can produce a claim that puts him outside God's judgment.

They are all under sin.

The problem was clearly expressed

There comes a point when the question is no longer whether something is wrong, or who is more wrong.

The question is whether anyone has a defense before God.

Romans has brought us to that point. Paul has spoken about those who suppress the truth, those who judge others while practicing the same things, and those who possess the law yet break it. Every possible claim of advantage has been examined.

Now the law speaks.

It does not give the person under it a final argument to present before God. It closes the argument. The law speaks so that every mouth may be closed and the whole world may be brought under the judgment of God.

The problem is not that people need a little more time, more effort, more education, or greater sincerity. The law has already exposed

what those things cannot change: no human being can be justified before God by works of the law.

Through the law comes the knowledge of sin.

That is the point Paul has reached. The person without the law has no excuse. The person who judges has no excuse. The person who has the law has no excuse. No one has a claim to present that puts him outside God’s judgment.

There is no comparison left to make.

No privilege left to claim.

No work of the law left to offer as justification.

Every mouth is closed.

> … whatever things the law says, it speaks to those who are under the law, that every mouth may be closed, and all the world may be brought under the judgment of God.
>
> — Romans 3:19

The Standard That Doesn’t Move

The urge to fix things is strong. Almost automatic. When something is wrong, we think that with enough correction, enough effort, enough learning, enough sincerity, it can be made right.

But correction is not the same as justification.

A person may become more disciplined, more informed, more intentional. Those changes may affect what he does next. But they do not, by themselves, provide an answer before God for what has already been done.

Knowing more does not remove the knowledge of sin.

Good intentions do not become a defense before God’s judgment.

The problem is not simply that behavior needs adjustment. Paul has brought us to something deeper. God’s judgment is according to truth. The standard does not lower itself to match our progress, our comparison with others, or our claim to have improved.

What God requires remains what God requires.

This is where the illusion begins to become clear. The issue is not simply whether a person wants to do better. The issue is whether any human work can justify that person before God.

The realization comes in silence:

There is no future work that turns a past transgression into obedience.

There is no claim of progress that removes the knowledge of sin.

There is no argument that alters God's judgment.

At that moment, the question changes.

It is no longer, *"How do I fix this?"*

It becomes, *"What can I present before God?"*

And Paul's answer is disarming in its simplicity:

There is no work of the law that can justify a human being in His sight.

Not because Paul is measuring whether the effort was sincere.

Not because he is denying that people can make changes in their conduct.

But because the law does not supply justification. Through the law comes the knowledge of sin.

The law speaks to those who are under the law so that every mouth may be closed. It does not hand anyone a final defense. It closes the argument.

The person without the law cannot claim innocence.

The person who judges cannot claim distance.

The person who has the law cannot claim that hearing it makes him righteous.

The person entrusted with God's revelations cannot claim that privilege excuses unfaithfulness.

Every mouth is closed.

And yet the thought remains:

There must be something I can do.

That thought is understandable. In most areas of life, effort changes things. When something breaks, we repair it. When we

fall behind, we work harder. When we lack knowledge, we study. Persistence often changes results.

But Romans 3:20 is not discussing whether effort can improve ordinary areas of life. It is dealing with justification before God.

More commitment may change future habits.

More discipline may change future choices.

More learning may make a person more aware of what is right.

But none of these becomes a justification before God. None turns the law into a defense. None removes the fact that through the law comes the knowledge of sin.

The question therefore keeps narrowing.

It is no longer, *"What else can I try?"*

It becomes, *"Can anything I do establish my righteousness before God?"*

Paul's answer is no: by works of the law, no flesh will be justified in His sight.

This is not a denial that actions matter. Romans has already shown that God judges according to truth. It is not a statement that knowledge, discipline, or sincerity have no place in human life. It is a statement about the problem now before us.

They cannot justify.

The law does not bend because someone has made progress.

It does not become less true because someone has good intentions.

It does not stop exposing sin because someone has learned to speak about righteousness.

It remains what it is.

> … by the works of the law, no flesh will be justified in his sight; for through the law comes the knowledge of sin.
>
> — Romans 3:20

What opposes us is not merely a list of mistakes we would prefer to forget. Paul has said that Jews and Greeks are all under sin. The

law brings that sin into view, and it leaves no human work capable of establishing justification before God.

The issue is not confined to private conscience or social consequences. It concerns God’s judgment.

Nor is it answered by comparison. The question is not whether someone has done better than another person, or whether he now does better than he once did. The question is whether he can be justified before God by works of the law.

Paul’s answer remains the same.

No flesh will be justified.

That is why the internal discussion finally ends. Not because the person has exhausted every possible effort, but because the law has made clear what effort cannot accomplish.

It can expose sin.

It cannot justify the sinner.

The Purpose of the Law Is Clear

At this point, Paul clarifies what the law accomplishes in his argument with a precision that many overlook.

The law does not justify.

It brings the knowledge of sin.

It closes every mouth.

It brings the whole world under the judgment of God.

This image is powerful: every mouth shut.

Not because there is nothing to say, but because no human defense can justify anyone before God.

The law ends the appeal to comparison.

It ends the appeal to religious privilege.

It ends the appeal to having heard the truth.

It ends the appeal to works as a basis of justification.

The silence that follows is not the silence of a person who has run out of ideas. It is the end of a person making his own case before God.

There is no longer a claim to present that changes the verdict.

No argument that makes sin disappear.

No work of the law that turns the sinner into someone justified before God.

The conclusion is plain:

We cannot justify ourselves.

We are finished—finished with self-justification.

Not as an insult.

Not as a threat.

But as the recognition of what Paul has shown: the law can expose sin, but it cannot justify the sinner.

It speaks to those under it so that every mouth may be closed. It leaves no human privilege, moral comparison, religious identity, or work of the law standing as a defense.

This is not despair. It is clarity.

The law has done what Paul says it does. It has made sin known. It has brought the world under God’s judgment. It has brought self-justification to its end.

Movement 4 - God Acts

(Romans 3:21-31)

Will there be a solution?

At this point, the expected next step is judgment.

Paul has said that every mouth is closed and that the whole world has been brought under the judgment of God. Jews and Greeks are all under sin. No human work can justify anyone before Him.

The case has been made.

There is no defense left to offer.

No advantage left to claim.

No reason to expect anything but the verdict.

And then Paul writes two words that no one could have supplied:

> But now …
>
> — Romans 3:21

But now.

Paul does not lower the charge. He does not pretend that guilt has disappeared. He does something far more surprising.

These words do not mean that the standard has moved. They do not mean that sin has become less serious. They do not mean that God has lowered His judgment because human beings cannot meet it.

They mean that God is about to act.

So far, Paul has shown what human beings cannot establish for themselves. No amount of moral comparison, religious privilege, knowledge of the law, or work of the law can justify anyone before God.

But now a righteousness of God has been revealed apart from the law.

Not a human righteousness.

Not a better version of the righteousness we failed to produce.

Not a new strategy for becoming acceptable.

A righteousness **of God**.

This is the surprise. The people who have nothing left to present are not first told to manufacture something worthy of presentation. God reveals what comes from Him.

He does not act because those under sin have supplied some gain that makes Him their debtor. Paul says they are justified freely by His grace. God's action is not a wage paid in response to a human achievement.

And yet God does not act by setting aside His own righteousness. He acts to demonstrate it.

God does not simply announce that sin no longer matters. He addresses it. He does not merely offer encouragement to people who have failed. He provides what His judgment requires.

That is why this is not an improvement of the human system.

It is God's intervention.

The law had brought knowledge of sin. God now reveals His righteousness.

The law had closed every mouth. God now speaks.

The Answer Is a Person

The answer is not an idea.

The answer is a person.

The righteousness of God is revealed through faith in Jesus Christ to all and on all those who believe. Paul does not leave the matter in the realm of principle. He tells us where God's action is found.

> being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus,
>
> — Romans 3:24

To be justified is to be declared righteous before God. Paul says this justification is given freely by grace. It is not earned by works of the law. It comes through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.

Then Paul tells us more. God sent Christ as an atoning sacrifice through faith in His blood. Christ's death is not an illustration of

God’s willingness to help. It is the action by which God demonstrates His righteousness.

This is where the direction becomes specific.

The problem was not only that people had done wrong things. They stood under God’s judgment, with no work of the law able to justify them.

The answer is not that they learn a better way to live so that they can produce their own righteousness.

The answer is that God acts in Christ.

God remains just.

And God justifies the one who has faith in Jesus.

That is the miracle Paul announces. God is not made the debtor of those who have failed Him. He acts freely by grace. Yet He does not compromise His righteousness in doing so.

Christ is not merely an inspiration, an example to imitate, or a religious symbol.

He is the One in whom redemption is found.

Paul will now explain how God can remain just while justifying the one who has faith in Jesus.

What He Did

The solution does not lie only in who Christ is.

It lies in what God has done through Him.

The people Paul has described do not need a better example. They do not need a teacher who gives them a higher standard, or a helper who assists them in meeting the standard they have already failed to meet.

They need redemption.

Paul has just said that all have sinned and fall short of God’s glory. No flesh can be justified by works of the law. Then he says:

> being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus,
>
> — Romans 3:24

This is not a change in the seriousness of the problem. God has not lowered His judgment. He has acted.

The justification human beings could not establish by works is given freely by grace. The redemption they could not produce is in Christ Jesus.

Redemption is not a religious feeling. It is not an idea people use to speak more positively about themselves. It is God's action in Christ where the human problem could not be answered by human work.

Paul does not say that people discovered righteousness, developed it, or finally achieved it. He says that a righteousness of God has been revealed apart from the law. It is God's righteousness. It comes from Him.

And God does not act by ignoring His own judgment. Paul says that He sent Christ through faith in His blood to demonstrate His righteousness. The God before whom every mouth was closed is the God who acts in Christ.

That is why Christ is not help added to a human solution.

There was no human solution to complete.

The problem was not that people had nearly made themselves righteous and needed a little assistance at the end. They had no work of the law that could justify them before God.

God acts where human works cannot.

That is why faith matters.

Faith does not make redemption real. God has acted in Christ. Faith does not turn Christ's work into a successful work. God has already revealed His righteousness and provided redemption in Him.

Faith looks to the God who has acted.

Paul will make this contrast clear in the next chapter:

> But to him who doesn't work, but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is accounted for righteousness.
>
> — Romans 4:5

Paul is not saying that faith is another work for which God owes a reward. In the verses immediately before this, he contrasts wages earned by work with righteousness accounted by God. The one who believes does not come before God to collect what he has earned. He believes in the God who justifies the ungodly.

That is the turn.

The person does not present his moral effort as the ground of justification. He does not offer religious knowledge, discipline, or reform as payment. He believes in the One who justifies the ungodly.

The ground of justification changes completely.

It is no longer human work.

It is God’s grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.

Christ is not merely an inspiration, an example to imitate, or a religious symbol.

He is the One in whom redemption is found.

And faith is not admiration from a distance. It is believing the God who has acted in Christ.

MOVEMENT 4 (continued) - Going Back in History

(Romans 4:1–25)

If God has declared something so decisive, what does that verdict rest on?

Is it based on what a person has done?

Does it depend on what he might yet become?

Or is it grounded somewhere else entirely?

Paul does not leave those questions unanswered. Having shown that no one can be justified by the works of the law, he goes back in history—not to change the subject, and not merely to offer an inspiring example, but to show that this has been God's way from the beginning.

He brings forward Abraham.

Paul's question is direct:

> "What then will we say that Abraham, our forefather, has found according to the flesh?"
>
> — Romans 4:1

Abraham matters because he cannot be dismissed as an outsider to the promises. If anyone could claim an advantage before God, it would seem to be Abraham. But Paul immediately closes that path:

> "For if Abraham was justified by works, he has something to boast about, but not toward God."
>
> — Romans 4:2

Then Paul lets Scripture speak:

> "Abraham believed God, and it was accounted to him for righteousness."
>
> — Romans 4:3

Abraham is not introduced as a moral hero who reached a higher level of obedience. Paul does not rehearse his whole life. He asks

one question: on what basis was Abraham counted righteous before God?

The answer is not that Abraham worked his way into that verdict. He believed God.

Paul deliberately presses the difference between a wage and a gift. To the one who works, the reward is not counted as grace, but as something owed. If righteousness came that way, it would be payment. It would be something God owed to the person who had done enough.

But that is not Paul's argument.

> "But to him who doesn't work, but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is accounted for righteousness."
>
> — Romans 4:5

The contrast is decisive. God does not justify the person who has made himself ungodly no longer. He justifies the ungodly.

Faith, then, is not another work added to the list. It is not the one performance that finally makes a person worthy of payment. It rests in the God who acts.

Paul adds David as a second witness. David speaks of the man to whom God counts righteousness apart from works: iniquities forgiven, sins covered, sin not charged by the Lord. The blessing is not the result of a record that has finally become acceptable. It is God's action toward the one who cannot present such a record.

Then Paul asks when Abraham's faith was accounted to him for righteousness.

Was it after circumcision?

No. It was before.

That matters because circumcision was real, given by God, and significant. But it was not the basis of the verdict. Abraham received it afterward, as a sign and seal of the righteousness of the faith he already had while uncircumcised.

Paul is closing another possible refuge. The verdict cannot rest on possessing the sign, belonging to the right group, or standing inside a privileged history. Abraham becomes the father of all who

believe—not only those who are circumcised, but also those who walk in the faith he had before circumcision.

Paul then goes further. The promise that Abraham would be heir of the world was not through the law, but through the righteousness of faith. If those who are of the law are heirs, faith is emptied and the promise is made ineffective.

Why?

Because the law produces wrath. The law does not turn the guilty into heirs by giving them more to perform. It identifies disobedience. It establishes the measure. It cannot become the ground of the promise.

> "For this cause it is of faith, that it may be according to grace, to the end that the promise may be sure to all the offspring."
>
> — Romans 4:16

This is why Paul goes back to Abraham. The promise is sure because it is according to grace. It does not rest on the strength of the person who receives it. It rests on the God who made it.

And that brings Paul back to Abraham's faith itself.

Abraham did not believe in his own future ability. He did not look at his age, Sarah's dead womb, and conclude that he possessed the resources to bring the promise about. The promise stood against every natural expectation.

Yet Abraham believed God—the God "who gives life to the dead, and calls the things that are not, as though they were."

Against hope, he believed in hope.

Paul does not present Abraham as someone denying the difficulty. He presents him as one who looked to the promise of God. He did not waver through unbelief, but grew strong through faith, giving glory to God, fully assured that what God had promised, He was also able to perform.

That phrase matters: **giving glory to God**.

The human collapse in Romans began with people who knew God but did not glorify Him as God. Abraham's faith does the opposite. It does not make Abraham the source. It gives glory to the One who promised and who is able to perform.

Therefore, Paul says, it was accounted to him for righteousness.

But he immediately refuses to leave Abraham in the past.

> “Now it was not written that it was accounted to him for his sake alone, but for our sake also, to whom it will be accounted, who believe in him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead.”
>
> — Romans 4:23–24

The same God whom Abraham believed is now made known in the raising of Jesus our Lord from the dead.

And Paul brings the argument back to Christ:

> “Who was delivered up for our trespasses, and was raised for our justification.”
>
> — Romans 4:25

The verdict is not resting on a person’s past, his signs, his law, or his ability to produce what God requires. It rests in the God who promised, the God who justifies the ungodly, and the God who raised Jesus from the dead.

Only now is Paul ready to say what follows from being justified by faith.

Movement 5 – Standing before God as Justified

(Romans 5:1–11)

What Changed?

> Being therefore justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ; through whom we also have our access by faith into this grace in which we stand. …
>
> — Romans 5:1–2

After showing that God justifies the ungodly apart from works, Paul now states what follows.

The first result is not a command. It is peace with God.

This peace is not achieved by becoming calm enough, obedient enough, or certain enough. Paul says it comes **through our Lord Jesus Christ**. The relationship with God is no longer approached through human work, comparison, law, or personal worthiness. Justification has changed the matter.

Paul then adds that through Christ we have access by faith into grace.

This is not the picture of people standing outside, trying to persuade God to receive them. It is not the picture of people returning with a new achievement each time they want to draw near. Through Christ, they have access into grace.

And Paul says that this is the grace **in which we stand**.

A New Position

To stand in grace is to stand where grace has placed you.

Paul is not describing a person who has found a better method of self-improvement. He is describing a person whose standing before God is now through Christ. The ground is no longer what that person can produce. It is grace.

That is what changed.

The justified person does not have peace with God because he has solved every struggle within himself. He has peace with God through Jesus Christ.

He does not have access because he has made himself presentable. He has access through Jesus Christ.

He does not stand in grace because he has learned how to hold himself there. He stands in the grace into which Christ has brought him.

This does not make the Christian life unreal or effortless. Paul will immediately speak of sufferings. But suffering does not mean that peace with God has disappeared. Difficulty does not mean access has been withdrawn. The grace in which Paul says believers stand is the setting from which the rest of the life of faith is lived.

That is why Paul says:

> “We rejoice in hope of the glory of God.”
>
> — Romans 5:2

Hope enters because God’s action is not exhausted by the present moment. The God who has justified has also given a future that does not rest on human achievement.

But Paul does not describe this hope as escape from hardship.

> “Not only this, but we also rejoice in our sufferings, knowing that suffering produces perseverance; and perseverance, proven character; and proven character, hope.”
>
> — Romans 5:3–4

The Christian does not rejoice because suffering itself is good. Paul’s point is that suffering is no longer proof that God has abandoned the one He has justified. Even there, hope is not destroyed.

And hope does not disappoint, Paul says, because God’s love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit given to us.

Paul does not leave that love undefined. He points to its historical demonstration.

> “For while we were yet weak, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.”
>
> — Romans 5:6

This is the foundation beneath the peace, the access, and the hope.

Christ did not die for people after they had made themselves strong. He died while they were weak.

He did not die for people after they had become godly. He died for the ungodly.

Paul presses the point further: while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. God’s love did not begin as a response to something found in us. God commended His own love toward us by acting while we were still sinners.

That changes the question completely.

The basis of peace with God is not that the person who receives it has become sufficient. The basis is that Christ died for the ungodly.

Paul then argues from what God has already done to what He will yet do:

> “Much more then, being now justified by his blood, we will be saved from God’s wrath through him.”
>
> — Romans 5:9

The movement is not from human weakness toward God’s acceptance. It is from God’s action toward the weak, sinners, and enemies to the future He has promised through Christ.

Paul says the same when he speaks of reconciliation:

> “For if while we were enemies, we were reconciled to God through the death of his Son, much more, being reconciled, we will be saved by his life.”
>
> — Romans 5:10

Reconciliation is not a person slowly making his way back to God. It is what God accomplished through the death of His Son while we were enemies.

This is why Paul’s conclusion is not confidence in human consistency. It is rejoicing in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received the reconciliation.

The change is real.

We have peace with God.

We have access into grace.

We stand in that grace through Christ.

We have hope because God acted while we were weak, sinners, and enemies.

And we rejoice—not first in what we have become, but in God through our Lord Jesus Christ.

A Novel Situation

Because this situation is real, life is no longer lived from uncertainty.

The relationship with God is not negotiated day by day. Paul has said that, being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ. Through Him, we have access by faith into the grace in which we stand.

That is already established.

The standing before God is not built from a person’s ability to maintain a better record. It rests on what Christ accomplished. The one who has been justified does not stand before God waiting to discover whether peace will hold. Paul says that peace is already his through Christ.

This changes the way everyday life is approached.

Difficulties do not disappear, but they no longer carry the same message. They are not evidence that peace with God has been lost. They do not reopen the question of whether Christ’s work was enough. Paul speaks of sufferings from within this grace, not as a threat to it.

Suffering produces perseverance. Perseverance produces proven character. Proven character produces hope.

And hope does not disappoint, because God’s love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit.

Paul then takes us back to the foundation of that hope. Christ did not act after we had become strong. He acted while we were weak. He did not die for people after they had made themselves godly. He died for the ungodly.

While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.

While we were enemies, we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son.

That is why the future is settled.

> “Much more then, being now justified by his blood, we will be saved from God’s wrath through him.”
>
> — Romans 5:9

Paul does not present this as a possibility. He does not say that those justified by Christ’s blood may yet need to make the verdict hold. He says that those who are now justified **will be saved** from God’s wrath through Christ.

The work that established peace with God is not waiting to be completed by the person who has received it. The one who was justified while ungodly is not now placed under a different basis. God does not reconcile enemies through the death of His Son and then place the future of that reconciliation back into their hands.

Paul says it again:

> “For if while we were enemies, we were reconciled to God through the death of his Son, much more, being reconciled, we will be saved by his life.”
>
> — Romans 5:10

The reasoning is unmistakable. If God acted when we were enemies, if Christ’s death reconciled us when we had nothing to offer, then reconciliation is not a temporary arrangement. The future is not left open for us to secure by our own performance.

This is what has changed.

Peace with God is not pending.

Access into grace is not pending.

Reconciliation is not pending.

Salvation from God’s wrath is not pending.

The one who has been justified by Christ’s blood will be saved through Him.

This is not a spiritual bank account that rises on good days and falls on bad ones. It is not a relationship that has to be re-established after every failure. God has resolved what stood between Himself and the one He has justified.

That is why Paul speaks of standing in grace.

It is settled.

Movement 6 — Sin Repositioned

(Romans 5:12–6:23)

Why Does Tension Persist?

After declaring that those justified by Christ's blood will be saved from God's wrath, Paul turns to the question his teaching immediately raises:

> What shall we say then? Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound?
>
> — Romans 6:1

This is not a side question. If grace has abounded where sin abounded, does sin no longer matter? Does the settled work of God make continuing in sin acceptable?

Paul's answer is immediate:

> May it never be! We who died to sin, how could we live in it any longer?
>
> — Romans 6:2

Paul does not weaken grace in order to make sin serious. He does not make justification less settled in order to make obedience necessary. He shows that something has changed in relation to sin itself.

That brings a personal question into view.

Why does sin still appear so persistent?

Why can a person know that God has acted, know that peace with God is settled, and still find himself facing temptation, failure, and the weight of what he has done?

Paul will not answer that by telling us that sin is unimportant. Nor will he answer it by telling us to try harder until the struggle disappears. He takes us beneath individual acts and shows us what sin has been doing from the beginning.

I lived for years struggling with sins in my life. Many of them were hidden from the people I ministered to as a missionary.

My life became a cycle of fighting sin. I was focused on my enemy. I tried to manage it, control it, defeat it.

Worst of all was discovering that, after all the effort, I had no victory to show for it.

Only cycles.

That forced me to ask a deeper question:

What if the problem was not only what I was doing? What if I had been treating sin only as behavior, when Paul describes something much greater?

Background Explanation

Enter Adam.

Paul does not introduce Adam merely as the first person who made a bad decision. He says that through one man sin entered the world, and death through sin. Death then passed to all because all sinned.

Sin entered. Death followed. And death reigned.

Paul's language is larger than a list of individual failures. Sin is not only something people do. It is a power that reigns. Death is not only an event at the end of life. It is the reign that followed sin into the world.

But Paul does not leave Adam standing alone.

The whole point of Romans 5:12–21 is the contrast between Adam and Christ. Through Adam came sin, condemnation, and death. Through Christ came grace, the gift, justification, and life.

Sin reigned in death.

Grace reigns through righteousness to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

That is why Paul can move into Romans 6 without reopening the question of justification. God's verdict has not become uncertain because sin remains a real power in the world. Christ's work is greater than Adam's trespass.

But Paul now tells us something specific about those who have been joined to Christ: they died to sin.

They were baptized into Christ's death. Their old man was crucified with Him so that they would no longer be in bondage to sin. They are to consider themselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus.

This is why Paul can command them:

> Therefore don't let sin reign in your mortal body, that you should obey it in its lusts.
>
> — Romans 6:12

Sin is still serious. Its desires still seek obedience. Paul does not tell believers to ignore it, excuse it, or make peace with it.

But he does not describe it as their ruler.

> For sin will not have dominion over you, for you are not under law, but under grace.
>
> — Romans 6:14

That is the change.

Sin is not harmless.

Sin is not imaginary.

Sin is not merely a private weakness to be managed.

But sin is no longer the master of the one who has died and risen with Christ.

This is why a series of better decisions could never have been the final answer. Good decisions cannot free a slave from his master. Paul's answer is not first a better strategy for controlling behavior. It is the death and resurrection of Christ, and the believer's union with Him.

Then Paul gives commands. Do not let sin reign. Do not present your members to sin. Present yourselves to God as alive from the dead.

Those commands do not rebuild justification. They follow from what Christ has done.

The question is no longer whether God's verdict will stand. That has been settled.

The question now is: if sin is no longer your master, whom will you present yourself to?

The Decisive Contrast: Adam and Christ

Paul does not bring Adam into the argument as a historical detail.

He brings him in because something entered the human story through him that no person could solve by simply trying harder.

Through one man, sin entered the world.

Through sin came death.

And death passed to all people, because all sinned.

Paul is not denying individual responsibility. All sinned. But he is showing that sin is more than the next wrong decision. Sin entered, death followed, and death reigned.

That is the world into which every person is born.

We know sin as something we do. Paul does not deny that. But in Romans 5, he asks us to see something larger. Sin is not only an action that needs correcting. It is connected to a reign of death that began through Adam and spread through humanity.

That is why a better series of decisions could never be enough to reverse the problem.

The problem was not only that people made bad choices.

Sin had entered.

Death had reigned.

Then Paul places Christ beside Adam.

Not because the two are equal.

They are not.

The free gift is not like the trespass.

Through Adam’s trespass came condemnation. Through Christ came the free gift that resulted in justification.

Through Adam’s disobedience, many were made sinners. Through Christ’s obedience, many will be made righteous.

Through Adam, death reigned.

Through Christ, grace reigns.

Paul is not describing two equal forces competing for control. He is not saying that sin abounded and grace barely managed to answer it.

He says something much stronger.

The law came in so that the trespass might abound.

> But where sin abounded, grace abounded more exceedingly.
>
> — Romans 5:20

Sin abounded.

It was not small.

It was not superficial.

It was not something humanity could overcome by trying to become a little better.

But grace abounded more exceedingly.

Grace did not merely match sin.

It overflowed beyond it.

The free gift followed many trespasses and resulted in justification. God did not answer only Adam’s trespass. He answered the entire accumulation of human sin that followed.

That is why Paul can bring the whole contrast to this conclusion:

> …that as sin reigned in death, even so grace might reign through righteousness to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.
>
> — Romans 5:21

Sin reigned in death.

Grace reigns through righteousness.

And grace’s reign leads to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

This is the decisive contrast.

The human story began under sin and death through Adam.

But the reign of grace through righteousness is greater than the reign of sin through death.

The person justified through Christ is not left wondering whether sin has the final word over his standing before God. Grace reigns through righteousness to eternal life.

That is what God has done.

The Inevitable Objection

Once Paul has said that grace abounded more exceedingly where sin abounded, the next question is unavoidable:

> What shall we say then? Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound?
>
> — Romans 6:1

Paul does not answer by reducing grace.

He does not say that grace may not abound after all.

He does not pull back from justification.

He does not put the person who has been justified back under uncertainty.

His answer is immediate:

> May it never be! We who died to sin, how could we live in it any longer?
>
> — Romans 6:2

Paul's answer is not, first, an instruction.

It is a declaration.

We died to sin.

That is why continuing in sin cannot be treated as though nothing has changed. The one who has died to sin cannot continue to think of sin as home.

Paul will now explain what this death to sin means.

But the foundation is already in place.

Grace has not made sin harmless.

Grace has done something greater.

It has brought the person who was under sin and death into a new relation to both.

It is settled.

Death and Life: Categories, Not Metaphors

Paul does not speak of death and life as passing sensations.

He grounds them in what happened through union with Christ.

Those baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into His death. They were buried with Him, so that, as Christ was raised from the dead, they also might walk in newness of life.

Paul does not say that temptation has disappeared. He says that the old man was crucified with Christ so that they would no longer be in bondage to sin.

Sin is still serious. Its desires are real. But the believer is no longer to think of himself as sin's servant.

Paul's instruction comes after what Christ has done:

> Thus consider yourselves also to be dead to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord.
>
> — Romans 6:11

The truth is not created by feeling it. Paul says what has happened in Christ, then calls the believer to reckon with it.

Identity Precedes Behavior

Paul's order matters.

He does not say, "Free yourself from sin so that you may become alive to God."

He says that those united with Christ died with Him and live to God in Him. Then he calls them to live in keeping with what God has done.

The exhortation rests on a fact.

The person does not obey in order to be crucified with Christ. He obeys because Paul has said that he was crucified with Christ.

That does not make obedience a way to secure acceptance. Peace with God, justification, and reconciliation have already been established through Christ.

But neither does Paul treat behavior as irrelevant. He asks whom a person presents himself to and obeys.

Obedience Changes Nature

Paul's image is slavery.

The question is not whether sin is harmless. It is not.

The question is whom a person will serve.

> Don't you know that when you present yourselves as servants and obey someone, you are the servants of whomever you obey, whether of sin to death, or of obedience to righteousness?
>
> — Romans 6:16

Paul does not use "righteousness" as a way to earn a standing before God. He has already established that righteousness was given through Christ.

He is showing the difference between the former slavery to sin and the new service of God.

The believer has been made free from sin and has become a servant of righteousness. This is not the loss of freedom. It is freedom from the master that led to death, so that life may now be offered to God.

The Fruit Reveals Dominance

Paul asks the reader to look at the outcome of sin's rule:

> What fruit then did you have at that time in the things of which you are now ashamed? For the end of those things is death.
>
> — Romans 6:21

Sin produces fruit.

Its end is death.

Paul then gives the contrast:

> But now, being made free from sin and having become servants of God, you have your fruit of sanctification and the result of eternal life.
>
> — Romans 6:22

The contrast is not between people who have done enough and people who have not.

It is between two masters and their outcomes.

Sin produces shame and ends in death.

Service to God bears the fruit of sanctification and ends in eternal life.

Paul is not asking fruit to establish the verdict God has already given through Christ. He is showing that sin and righteousness do not lead to the same end.

This is why Romans 6 does more than tell us to manage sinful behavior. Paul says that our old man was crucified with Christ so that we would no longer be in bondage to sin.

> …our old man was crucified with him, that the body of sin might be done away with, so that we would no longer be in bondage to sin.
>
> — Romans 6:6

Sin is still serious.

It is still harmful.

But it is no longer sovereign.

It no longer determines the verdict before God. The person justified by Christ is not returned to condemnation every time sin appears. God has already resolved the relationship.

That is where the title of this book lands with force:

It is settled.

Not because the believer has solved every struggle, but because God has settled what stood between Himself and the one He justified.

So Why Do I Sin?

Romans 6 does not answer this by sending the believer back to uncertainty about his standing.

Paul says that those who died with Christ are to consider themselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus. He is not

giving them a technique for making God's work real. He is calling them to reckon with what God has already done.

The question is no longer, "Can I make myself acceptable to God?"

That question has been answered in Christ.

The question is, "Will I keep presenting myself to the master from whom Christ has freed me?"

This is where counting on what is real becomes essential.

Not as a way to produce justification.

Not as a way to make peace with God hold.

But because grace has brought the believer out from sin's dominion and into the life of God.

Trusting What's Real

Scripture does not speak of merely showing up. Paul says:

> Thus consider yourselves also to be dead to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord.
>
> — Romans 6:11

This is not about gaining a standing before God.

That has already been established through Christ.

It is about reckoning with what God has said is true. The believer is not asked to make himself dead to sin so that God will receive him. He is told to consider himself dead to sin because he has died with Christ.

This does not mean that sin has been annihilated. Paul still speaks of a mortal body and its lusts. But sin is no longer the master it once was.

That changes the ground from which the Christian life is lived.

A person no longer needs to return to the old effort of trying to gain from God what Christ has already accomplished. He does not live before God by measuring whether his record is good enough today.

> "But the righteous shall live by faith."
>
> — Romans 1:17

Faith does not make sin insignificant.

Faith does not deny the seriousness of wrongdoing.

Faith receives what God has done through Christ and refuses to return to the old attempt at self-righteousness.

The believer does not count on himself to become acceptable. He counts on Christ, who has already made peace with God, brought him into grace, and freed him from sin’s dominion.

That is what is real.

Movement 7 — The Law to Live

(Romans 7)

The wrong fuel

Another question arises at this point.

If standing before God is real and the struggle is still happening, why is it sometimes so hard to do the right thing?

The problem is not always a lack of knowledge. A person may know what is good—even want to do it—and still fail to carry it out.

> … For desire is present with me, but I don’t find it doing that which is good.
>
> — Romans 7:18

This is where many turn to motivation.

“Don’t give up.”

“Try harder.”

“Do your best.”

When that motivation wears off, guilt can take its place. And the law, because it names what is wrong so clearly, can become a constant source of pressure.

Maybe you never miss a meeting.

You read your Bible.

You serve faithfully.

But you live under constant evaluation. When you have a good spiritual day, you breathe. When you fail, you shrink. Your sense of peace rises and falls with your performance.

That is not necessarily a lack of commitment.

It is living under measurement.

The law is clear. It draws boundaries. It exposes sin. But knowing exactly where you failed does not, by itself, give you the power to do what is right.

So guilt becomes fuel—until the fuel runs out. It may drive another attempt, followed by frustration, followed by exhaustion.

> … but when the commandment came, sin revived and I died.
>
> — Romans 7:9

Paul is careful about what happened there. The commandment was not evil. He calls it holy, righteous, and good. He even says it was *for life*. But sin found an opportunity through the commandment, deceived him, and brought death.

The law revealed what was right. Sin used that good commandment against him.

Two Cycles

Using the law as motivation often creates a cycle.

A person realizes what is wrong, feels guilty, tries harder, fails, and then feels guilty again.

Sometimes the cycle is different.

Conscience leads to guilt, guilt to effort, effort to temporary success—and success becomes pride.

Neither path produces the life the person is trying to reach. In both cases the standard becomes clearer, but the ability to meet it does not increase.

This is not because the law is bad. Paul will not say that. The trouble is sin, which can use even a good commandment as an opportunity.

Something else happened when our standing before God was established.

A person was not only given peace with God through Christ. Paul says that through the body of Christ we were **made dead to the law** and joined to the One raised from the dead, “that we might produce fruit to God” (Romans 7:4).

That is more than finding a better source of motivation. It is a change in whom we belong to. Having died to what held us, Paul says, we now serve “in newness of the spirit, and not in oldness of the letter” (Romans 7:6).

> through whom we also have our access by faith into this grace in which we stand. …
>
> — Romans 5:2

This is the grace in which we stand. And grace does not leave us without instruction: Titus 2:11–12 says that God’s grace teaches us to deny ungodliness and live rightly in this present age.

The law remains good. But it is not the fuel by which we earn or keep peace with God. Joined to Christ, we serve in newness of the Spirit.

A New Authority

Grace does not use guilt as fuel.

It works differently.

Paul says we were made dead to the law through Christ’s body and joined to the One raised from the dead, **“that we might produce fruit to God”** (Romans 7:4). He says we now serve **“in newness of the spirit, and not in oldness of the letter”** (Romans 7:6).

This is not effort-based performance to gain a position before God.

The position has already been established through Christ. The life that follows is lived in dependence on Him, not under pressure to make Him accept us.

When a person tries to move forward as though every failure might undo what Christ has done, guilt may drive another attempt. But it cannot become the source of this new life. The old cycle can return: effort, failure, self-condemnation, and another promise to try harder.

The standing is real.

Being joined to Christ is real.

The answer is not to make guilt work harder.

Grace is not passive. Titus 2:11–12 says that God’s grace instructs us to deny ungodliness and live rightly in this present age. It does not leave us where sin had us. And Romans 7 says that those joined to Christ now serve in newness of the Spirit.

The law showed what was right, but sin used even that good commandment to bring death. God has done more than repeat the demand. Through Christ, He has brought us into a new kind of service.

The problem was not merely that we needed to know the standard. We needed what the law could not give.

When Wanting Is Not Doing

Paul has said that the law is holy, righteous, and good. Now he speaks of wanting to do what is good and doing what he hates instead.

He does not describe indifference. He agrees that the law is good. He says he delights in God’s law inwardly. Desire is present, but he cannot find the doing of the good he desires.

That is what makes this passage so difficult to brush aside. Another command will not tell him something he does not already know. And telling him to want the good more does not answer him either. He wants it.

As a missionary, I can relate to that struggle. I knew we were not to live under the law. What I did not realize was that I had made a law of my own. I felt I needed to read my Bible every day, pray after reading, read through the Bible in one year, go to church, and give at least my tithe.

Most of the time I could not keep my own rules, and I felt guilty. So I did my best and disciplined myself. When I managed to keep them, I felt more acceptable to God. Then I became proud. My pride led me to hurt somebody else, and afterward I felt guilty about that too.

Around it went: guilt, effort, pride, harm, guilt again. I was living out of the flesh, a slave to my own passions and desires. Quite frankly, it was exhausting. And to be honest, I was not much fun to be around.

Paul does not blame the goodness of the law for the evil he practices. He says sin dwells in him. He still calls the evil *his doing*. But agreeing with what is right has not delivered him from

it. He sees the conflict clearly and cannot bring it to an end by wanting harder.

So his question changes:

> What a wretched man I am! Who will deliver me out of the body of this death? I thank God through Jesus Christ, our Lord!
>
> — Romans 7:24–25

Who will deliver me?

Paul thanks God through Jesus Christ. Today, I can say the same. I am learning to live the Christian life free from sin's dominion and empowered by His Spirit. This is not a method I learned or a secret I discovered. God is delivering me through Jesus Christ.

Paul has already said that sin will not have dominion over us because we are under grace, not law. Now Romans 8 will show what it means to walk according to the Spirit.

Movement 8 — Life Lived with Power

(Romans 8)

There is no more condemnation

Now there is no condemnation.

Paul does not say there is less condemnation than before. He says there is **none** for those who are in Christ Jesus.

This is not because the standard has disappeared or the past has been ignored. Paul tells us what happened:

> For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus made me free from the law of sin and of death.
>
> — Romans 8:2

The law could show what was right. It could expose sin. But, weakened through the flesh, it could not accomplish what was needed.

God did.

He sent His own Son and condemned sin in the flesh, so that the law's requirement might be fulfilled in those who walk according to the Spirit. The answer was not another demand placed on people who could not meet it. God acted where the law could not.

That is why the gospel is the power of God for salvation. It is not simply information about forgiveness, and it is not encouragement to make a better effort. God has acted through His Son, and the Spirit of life is now at work in those who belong to Him.

Life is no longer driven by the need to escape condemnation. In Christ, there is none.

Life and Peace

Paul does not leave the Spirit's work as an abstract idea. He speaks about what people set their minds on, how they live, and whom they belong to.

> For the mind of the flesh is death, but the mind of the Spirit is life and peace.
>
> — Romans 8:6

Life and peace are not a promise that every day will feel peaceful. Paul is describing the difference between life governed by the flesh and life in the Spirit. The Spirit of God dwells in those who belong to Christ.

That presence makes a real difference. Paul does not tell them to draw strength from guilt or fear. He says that **by the Spirit** they put to death the deeds of the body. They are led by the Spirit of God. They have received the Spirit of adoption and cry, “Abba! Father!”

Daily life still involves decisions. Sin is still something to resist. But the justified person has not been left with a clear standard and the same old source of strength. God has given His Spirit.

Peace here is not the absence of difficulty.

It is life with God through the Spirit He has given.

Present Struggle, Future Completion

Life does not become painless. The world does not suddenly cooperate.

Paul says creation groans. Even those who have the first fruits of the Spirit groan as they wait for the redemption of their bodies. Something decisive has happened, but the body’s redemption is still ahead.

The Spirit is present in that waiting. He helps in our weakness and intercedes when we do not know how to pray as we ought.

So suffering does not mean God stopped halfway. Paul looks toward the glory to be revealed, and he traces that future through God’s own purpose: those He called, He also justified; those He justified, He also glorified.

The future is not held together by our ability to remain strong. Paul’s confidence rests in the God who has acted and who will bring His purpose to completion.

Nothing separates

Then Paul asks who can bring a charge against those God has chosen.

It is God who justifies.

Who is the one who condemns?

Christ died. He was raised. He is at God’s right hand, and He intercedes for us.

Paul’s final words do not float above those facts. They follow from them:

> For I am persuaded that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor things present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor any other created thing will be able to separate us from God’s love which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.
>
> — Romans 8:38–39

Nothing in that list has authority to overturn what God has done in Christ.

Not suffering.

Not a charge brought against the one God justifies.

Not death or life, things present or things to come.

Paul is not trying to create a reassuring mood. He is answering the question of who could condemn and who could separate. His answer is grounded in God’s verdict, Christ’s death and resurrection, and Christ’s continuing intercession.

This is life on dry land, not idealistic thinking above it. There is weakness, and the Spirit helps. There is suffering, and glory is coming. There are accusations, and God justifies. There is death, and the God who raised Jesus will give life to our mortal bodies.

What God established through Christ does not loosen when life becomes hard. His purpose does not stop halfway.

No condemnation in Christ. No separation from God’s love in Christ.

Movement 9 — Historical Proof

(Romans 9-11)

The Broadest Evidence

At this point a question naturally arises.

And what about Israel?

God gave them promises.

They were chosen to be his nation.

They were entrusted with revelation.

And yet, history shows repeated failures.

> I will make of you a great nation. I will bless you and make your name great. You will be a blessing.
>
> — Genesis 12:2

At first glance, it may seem that the promises were not kept.

It may seem that human failure canceled out divine promise.

Some even conclude that God took back what He once declared.

But that conclusion doesn’t match the big picture.

Israel’s history is not a history of promises made and then erased.

It is a story of promises preserved despite human incoherence.

There were consequences.

There were seasons of distance.

There were national and personal failures.

But the promises themselves did not dissolve.

This distinction is important.

Human response influenced the experience.

It did not annul what God established.

What God declared did not disappear when people faltered.

It remained, often carried out through corrections, restorations, and time.

Israel becomes proof of a greater truth:

God’s faithfulness is not fragile.

It is not undone by human weakness.

The pattern observed in Israel is not abandonment; it is persistence. Not of men, but of God.

Failure brought discipline, but discipline did not equate to rejection.

The delay did not amount to cancellation.

Correction does not equate to reversal.

The promises were not recovered.

They were maintained.

And that is why Israel matters in this discussion.

Israel’s story shows, at the national level, what has already been said on a personal level:

What God establishes, He sustains. Human inconsistency affects the journey, but it does not change the destination.

This is not selective memory.

It is observable history.
We can see God is faithful to his word.

The same faithfulness that preserved God’s purposes with Israel is the faithfulness that secures what has been established in Christ.

Evidence is not abstract.

It is written over generations.

This broader view eliminates a common misunderstanding.

Israel’s history is not proof that God changes His mind.

It is proof that he does not.

There were times when the road became difficult, times when people moved away, periods marked by loss and exile.

However, even in those seasons, the foundation did not disappear.

What God had said did not dissolve with circumstances.

Promises Kept

> For I don’t desire you to be ignorant, brothers, of this mystery, so that you won’t be wise in your own conceits, that a partial hardening has happened to Israel, until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in, and so all Israel will be saved. Even as it is written, “There will come out of Zion the Deliverer, and he will turn away ungodliness from Jacob. This is my covenant with them, when I will take away their sins.”
>
> — Romans 11:25–27

The promises were not fragile agreements waiting to be broken.

They were rooted in God’s own purpose. And His purpose does not fluctuate as human determination does.

Looking at Israel across generations reveals a difficult pattern. The human response goes up and down. There is unbelief, and Paul does not pretend otherwise. He says that branches were broken off because of it. He warns Gentiles, too: they stand by faith, not by some advantage of their own.

Yet Paul refuses to conclude that God’s word has failed.

God has not rejected His people. There is a remnant. The hardening is partial. The branches that do not continue in unbelief can be grafted in again. And after speaking of the Deliverer and the covenant, Paul says that God’s gifts and calling are irrevocable.

From this angle, Israel is no exception to the message. Israel brings the question into the open: **Can human failure bring God’s word to nothing?** Paul’s answer is no.

But Israel’s promise and the standing of a person justified through faith in Christ are not interchangeable. Paul has given that standing its own foundation. In Romans 8, God is the One who justifies. Christ died, was raised, and intercedes. Paul asks who can bring a charge, who can condemn, and what can separate those in Christ from God’s love. His answers are not tentative.

So what does all this mean?

It means that the relationship God has established through Christ is not built on personal strength, personal consistency, or personal effort. The person He has justified is not left to maintain God’s verdict day after day. Its foundation is what God has done.

It also means that struggle and failure do not get to pronounce a new verdict. Paul's warning about unbelief is real; he does not use God's faithfulness to make unbelief harmless. But neither does he make the justified person's standing depend on an unbroken record of personal success. The ground beneath that relationship does not rise and fall with performance.

Life is no longer an attempt to secure belonging by effort. What God has done through Christ is not waiting for human beings to make it firm.

God's faithfulness is greater than human weakness.

The sufficiency of Christ is greater than personal failure.

God's love in Christ is not temporary, and His purpose is not easily reversed.

This is why Israel matters here. Paul does not set aside the painful facts of its history. He faces them and still says that God has not rejected His people. Israel's unbelief has not made His word come to nothing.

Christian security is not naïve. Paul has made the question of God's faithfulness face history.

Romans 8 is not merely an emotional high point. Paul gives reasons for what he says there. Romans 9–11 then confronts a question those words make unavoidable: what about Israel? Paul's answer does not erase either Israel's unbelief or God's promise. He holds both before us, and insists that God's word stands.

The reader can leave this part of Romans knowing God better. Not as someone who looks away when people fail, and not as someone whose purpose collapses when they do. He is faithful to what He has said.

That is why the standing God has given those He justified in Christ is no fragile arrangement. The verdict rests with Him.

Epilogue — By the Mercies of God

Paul does not end his letter at chapter 11. He goes on to speak about serving, loving, giving, living alongside others, and receiving people with whom we disagree. After everything he has said about justification by faith, what are we to make of these instructions?

His opening words tell us how to read them.

> Therefore I urge you, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your spiritual service.
>
> — Romans 12:1

By the mercies of God. The appeal proceeds from the mercy Paul has been explaining. God justifies freely by his grace through the redemption in Christ Jesus (3:24). Those justified by faith have peace with God through him (5:1). Paul now appeals to these people to present their lives to God on that basis.

Their service does not supply something missing from the redemption. Paul has already distinguished a wage owed for work from righteousness counted to the one who believes in the God who justifies the ungodly (4:4–5). The presence of work in the Christian life does not turn that gift into a wage.

We can see this in the way Paul describes their service. They are members of one body in Christ, with different gifts according to the grace given to them (12:4–6). Grace is already present when the serving begins. Teaching, giving, and showing mercy are uses of what God has given.

The same order becomes especially clear when Paul addresses their disagreements.

> Don’t let him who eats despise him who doesn’t eat. Don’t let him who doesn’t eat judge him who eats, for God has accepted him.
>
> — Romans 14:3

These believers disagree about food. One eats; another abstains. Paul does not tell them to settle the disagreement so that God can finally decide whether to receive them. He brings God’s

acceptance into the disagreement as a fact they must reckon with. Their brother is someone God has accepted.

That is why contempt and judgment are out of place. A brother's acceptance does not wait for the approval of the person sitting across the table from him. Paul asks who they are to judge another's servant, then directs their attention to God's power to make him stand (14:4).

He carries the argument further:

> For if we live, we live to the Lord. Or if we die, we die to the Lord. If therefore we live or die, we are the Lord's.
>
> — Romans 14:8

Paul grounds that belonging in Christ's death and resurrection: Christ died and lived again to be Lord of both the dead and the living (14:9). Even here, in the middle of a disagreement about ordinary conduct, the decisive explanation is what Christ has done.

Belonging to him includes accountability. Paul says that each will give account to God, and he warns against harming a brother for whom Christ died (14:10–15). Acceptance does not make the brother's treatment unimportant. It gives Paul a reason to insist that he be treated with care. The person being despised belongs to the Lord.

Then Paul states the connection plainly:

> Therefore accept one another, even as Christ also accepted you, to the glory of God.
>
> — Romans 15:7

Christ's acceptance is the basis of their welcome to one another. Paul is applying what has been given. He is not describing how they can earn it.

That connection remains as the letter turns to Paul's ministry and the people who shared in it. Paul speaks of what Christ worked through him (15:18). He names fellow workers, people who helped others, people who labored and opened their homes (16:1–16). Their service has a real place in the letter. Yet Paul has not exchanged the Christ who saves for a record of service that

justifies. Even his account of his own ministry points to Christ's work through him.

Romans 12–16 therefore belongs with the argument that came before it. The instructions address people on the basis of God's mercies, Christ's acceptance, and their belonging to the Lord. They do not introduce a second price for the justification Paul has called a gift.

The question this book has followed is what establishes our standing before God. Paul directs us to Christ: his blood, his resurrection, his intercession. He reasons from being justified by Christ's blood to being saved from wrath through him, and from reconciliation through his death to salvation by his life (5:9–10). When he asks who can bring a charge against God's chosen ones, his answer is that God justifies; when he asks who condemns, he points to Christ who died, rose, and intercedes for us (8:33–34).

The closing chapters do not replace that answer. The mercy from which Paul's appeal begins is the mercy his gospel has declared. Christ's acceptance remains the ground of the welcome he commands.

Our service is not the missing part of Christ's saving work. Our standing before God rests on the Christ through whom we have received reconciliation.

You know, I wish someone had taken the time years ago to show me how conclusive these truths are. Peace with God, reconciliation, standing in grace—these are realities we can count on. Seeing that in Romans has given me great confidence in my relationship with God. I hope this book has been a blessing to you as well.

I want to encourage you to study Romans verse by verse, truly listening to God speak through it. See for yourself what He has done and how firmly it stands.

It is settled.